LAUNCH ROADMAP

Brief! - from localhost to briefmessage.net

Version 1 | Planning document | Domain, hosting, billing, pricing

Purpose	The steps, in order, that turn Brief! from a project that runs on one computer into a product a team can sign up for and pay for at briefmessage.net.
Starting point	Brief! 2.2.0: Spring Boot backend, React web app, 149 tests written (2.1.0 verified at 133 of 133). Domain registered at Cloudflare on October 6, 2026. Nothing deployed.
Same playbook as	PixelPerfect Screenshot API: Render for hosting, PostgreSQL for data, Cloudflare in front, Stripe for billing. This document only spells out what is different for a Java application.
How to read the numbers	Prices and plan limits were checked on the vendor's own pages on October 6, 2026. Vendors change them. Confirm each figure on its pricing page before you act on it.
What this is not	Legal, tax or financial advice. Sections 9 and 11 list questions to settle with the right professional.

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1. Where Things Stand

You have	You do not have yet
A working application with accounts, posts, mentions, alerts, paging and an API documentation page	A deployment. It runs on your computer and your Wi-Fi only.
Security that would survive a review: hashed passwords, signed tokens, ownership rules, a login rate limit	HTTPS, which arrives with hosting
A domain: briefmessage.net, at Cloudflare	Any DNS records pointing it at anything
A database layer that already speaks to H2 and (untested) MySQL	PostgreSQL support, which Render's managed database requires
A repeatable test suite	Versioned database migrations, so a production schema can change safely
Experience launching PixelPerfect on the same vendors	Email on accounts: no password reset, no verification, no billing contact
One public board	Private boards. Today everyone who registers sees everything.
	Terms of service, privacy policy, pricing page, payment

The second column is the roadmap. Nothing in it is unusual, and you have done most of it once already for PixelPerfect.

2. The Decision That Comes First: What Is Being Sold

A domain makes the project feel like a product. It becomes one when a specific group of people can be named who would pay for it. OTSR v2 compared two directions and recommended the second. That recommendation stands, and the features built since (mentions, alerts) fit it.

	A public social board	B. Private boards for small teams (recommended)
Who	Anyone	A team of 3 to 30 that wants one place for short, must-read updates
Why they would use it	Because others are already there. With no users, there is no reason to come.	Because five colleagues are enough to make it useful on day one
The 255-character limit	A curiosity	The feature: every update is a summary, so every update gets read
Mentions and alerts	Nice to have	The reason to open it: "someone needs me"
Money	Advertising, which needs a very large audience	A small monthly subscription per board
Ongoing duty	Moderating strangers' content, at any size	Light: a private group moderates itself

Positioning (a hypothesis to test, not a fact)

One sentence to test on real people: "Brief! is a private board for your team where every post is 255 characters or less, so the things everyone must read do not drown in chat."

It does not replace Slack or Teams. It sits beside them, as the place for the few messages a day that must not be missed.

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Before investing further

Three honest risks. The market for team communication is crowded and the large tools have free tiers. "Brief" is a common word that other products use, so check for conflicting trademarks before spending on the brand. And this would be a third product beside PixelPerfect and ContentCalendar.ai, competing for the same hours.

Therefore: validate before building billing. After milestone M2 the app is online. Ask five real teams to use it free for two weeks. If at least two would pay, build M4 and M5. If none would, you have lost little and learned why.

3. The Roadmap: Seven Milestones

Each milestone ends in something you can check. Effort is a rough estimate for evenings beside your other work; treat it as an order of magnitude.

	Milestone	What is built or done	Done when	Effort
M0	**Secure the domain**	Auto-renew confirmed, DNSSEC on, account 2FA, a forwarding email address	A message to hello@briefmessage.net reaches your inbox	30 minutes, you
M1	**A deployable build** (Brief! 2.3)	PostgreSQL driver and profile. Flyway migrations replace `ddl-auto=update`; foreign keys added. Dockerfile. Real client address behind a proxy. Usernames unique regardless of capitals. Mentions endpoint paged.	The 2.3 tests pass on your machine against PostgreSQL, and `docker run` serves the app	About a week
M2	**Online**	Render web service and database; custom domain through Cloudflare; HTTPS; secrets set in Render	https://briefmessage.net shows Brief!, and data survives a redeploy	2 to 3 days
	Validation gate	*Five teams, two weeks, free. Decide whether to continue (Section 2).*		
M3	**Real accounts**	Email on accounts, verification link, password reset, a bot check at sign-up, account deletion, Terms and Privacy pages	A stranger can register, forget the password and recover it	1 to 2 weeks
M4	**Private boards**	Workspaces: every post belongs to one. Invitations by email. Roles: owner and member. A landing page for visitors who are not signed in.	Two teams use the same server and cannot see each other's posts	2 to 3 weeks
M5	**Payment**	Stripe Checkout, customer portal, webhooks; plan limits enforced; pricing page	A real card pays, the board is upgraded, and cancelling downgrades it	1 to 2 weeks
M6	**Launch**	Uptime monitoring, error alerts, tested database restore, support address, DMCA agent, announcement	You would be comfortable if a customer signed up while you slept	About a week

How this maps to the milestones in OTSR v2: the old M0 ("a link anyone can open") is M1 and M2 here, and part of it is already done (strong passwords, rate limit, signed tokens, paging). The old M1 (private groups) is M4 and the old M3 (paid) is M5. Accounts with email, M3 here, was not a separate step before. Of the old M2 ("daily habit"), mentions and automatic refresh exist; replies, search and a daily digest wait until after launch.

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4. briefmessage.net: What To Do Now

Your Cloudflare screen shows four "Next steps" cards. Here is what each means for Brief!, in the order to act.

Card on the screen	Do this	Why
Manage domain	Open it now. Under Configuration: confirm **Auto-renew** is on (it is by default). Click **Enable DNSSEC** (one click; it can take a day or two to become active). Leave the domain locked.	Auto-renew prevents losing the name by accident. DNSSEC stops forged DNS answers. Cloudflare already hides your contact details in WHOIS.
Deploy a site (Workers)	**Skip it for the application.**	Workers run JavaScript on Cloudflare's network. Brief!'s backend is a Java server, which they cannot run. The application goes on Render (Section 5); Cloudflare stays in front as DNS.
Protect your domain	Nothing yet. Return after M2.	There is no site to protect until DNS points somewhere. Section 6 lists the settings.
Register a new domain	Not needed.	One name is enough to launch.

Three more things worth doing today

1. **Protect the Cloudflare account itself.** The domain is only as safe as the login that controls it. Turn on two-factor authentication and check that the payment method on file will still be valid at renewal.
2. **Create a professional address.** In the Cloudflare dashboard open Email Routing for briefmessage.net, add `hello@briefmessage.net` and `support@briefmessage.net`, and forward both to your inbox. It is free, and Cloudflare adds the DNS records itself. It only receives; sending comes in M3 (Section 7).
3. **Know the 60-day rule.** A newly registered domain cannot be transferred to another registrar for 60 days. That affects nothing in this plan. Domains registered at Cloudflare must also use Cloudflare's nameservers, which is what you want.

Optional: if you would like the address to show something before M2, a single static "coming soon" page can be hosted on Cloudflare for free. It is not required, and the time is better spent on M1.

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5. Hosting on Render

The shape is the one you run for PixelPerfect, with one process instead of two: the Spring Boot jar serves both the API and the web app.

Piece	On Render	Note for a Java application
The application	A **web service** built from a **Dockerfile**	Render has no built-in Java runtime. Its documented route for Java is Docker.
The database	**Render Postgres**	Render offers no managed MySQL. Running MySQL yourself in a container means doing your own backups. PostgreSQL is the practical choice, and switching costs one driver and one profile because Hibernate writes the SQL.
Port	The app must listen on `0.0.0.0` at the port in `PORT`	Already done: `server.port=${PORT:8080}`
Health check	A path that answers 200 within five seconds	Already there: `/health`
Secrets	Environment variables in the dashboard	`BRIEF_JWT_SECRET` (let Render generate it), the database password
Instances	One	Correct for now: the rate-limit counts and the signed-out token list live in memory (Section 12).
Region	Virginia or Ohio	Closest to your first users. Put the database in the same region and use its internal address.

What M1 adds to the project

Dockerfile (a sketch; the tested version ships with 2.3)

```
# 1. build the jar
FROM eclipse-temurin:17-jdk AS build
WORKDIR /src
COPY backend-spring/ .
RUN chmod +x mvnw && \
    ./mvnw -q -DskipTests package

# 2. run it on a smaller image
FROM eclipse-temurin:17-jre
COPY --from=build \
     /src/target/brief-spring.jar /app.jar
ENTRYPOINT ["java", "-jar", "/app.jar"]
```

Settings on the Render web service

```
PORT                  set by Render
BRIEF_AUTH_MODE       strict
BRIEF_JWT_SECRET      generated by Render,
                      32+ characters
SPRING_PROFILES_ACTIVE   postgres
BRIEF_DB_URL          jdbc:postgresql://
                      <host>:<port>/<database>
BRIEF_DB_USER         from the database
BRIEF_DB_PASSWORD     from the database

Health check path     /health
```

- Render's database gives a connection string that begins `postgresql://`. Java needs the JDBC form, `jdbc:postgresql://host:port/database`, built from the host, port and database name that Render lists separately.
- In production the schema is created by **Flyway** migration files and Hibernate is set to `validate`. It then checks the schema and never changes it.
- The first deploy can be described in a `render.yaml` file kept in the repository, so the service, the database and their settings are recreated the same way every time.

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Which plan, when

Stage	Web service	Database	Per month	Good for
Try it	Free (512 MB)	Free Postgres (1 GB)	$0	M2, for a few days. The service sleeps after 15 minutes without traffic and takes about a minute to wake. **The free database is deleted 30 days after creation** and has no backups.
Validation and launch	Starter, 512 MB, $7	Smallest paid, 256 MB, $6	$13	Always on. Database backed up continuously, with recovery to any point in the last 3 days.
Growing	Standard, 2 GB, $25	1 GB, $19	$44	More memory for the Java process, more connections

Prices checked on the vendor's own pages on October 6, 2026. Database storage beyond the first gigabyte is billed per gigabyte. A Java process on 512 MB is workable for a small board but has little headroom; watch memory in the first week and move to 2 GB if it restarts.

6. Connecting Cloudflare to Render

These are Render's documented steps for a domain whose DNS is at Cloudflare. Do them after the service is running at its `onrender.com` address.

1. **Render:** open the web service, Settings, Custom Domains, and add `briefmessage.net`. Render adds `www.briefmessage.net` as well and redirects it to the main name.
2. **Cloudflare, DNS:** remove any `AAAA` records for the domain if there are any.
3. **Cloudflare, DNS:** add a `CNAME` record with name `@` and target `<your-service>.onrender.com`, proxy status **DNS only** (grey cloud). Add a second `CNAME` with name `www` and the same target, also DNS only.
4. **Cloudflare, SSL/TLS:** set the encryption mode to **Full**. Never "Flexible", which sends traffic to the server unencrypted.
5. **Render:** click Verify. Render issues the HTTPS certificate itself and renews it.
6. Open `https://briefmessage.net`. Register, post, reload.

A plain `CNAME` at the top of a domain is normally not allowed in DNS. Cloudflare makes it work automatically ("CNAME flattening"), on every plan.

Grey cloud or orange cloud?

	DNS only (grey)	Proxied (orange)
What Cloudflare does	Answers DNS. Visitors connect straight to Render.	Visitors connect to Cloudflare, which forwards to Render
You gain	Simplicity. Render's own network already includes protection against floods of traffic.	Cloudflare's cache for static files, its firewall rules, one free rate-limiting rule, redirect rules
You must handle	Nothing	The server sees Cloudflare's address, not the visitor's. The login rate limit must then read the `CF-Connecting-IP` header, or every visitor looks like the same one.
Recommendation	**Start here.** Render's guide requires it until the certificate is issued anyway.	Switch later, once 2.3 reads the forwarded address. Test by logging both headers on one request first.

After the site is live, under SSL/TLS, Edge Certificates: turn on **Always Use HTTPS**. Leave HSTS off until you are sure HTTPS will never be switched off; it is hard to undo.

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7. Email

Need	Service	Cost	When
Receive mail at your own domain	Cloudflare Email Routing: forwards to an inbox you already have. It adds its own MX and SPF records.	Free	M0
Send verification links, password resets, mention alerts	A transactional email provider, called from the application over HTTPS. Examples and their free allowances: Resend (3,000 a month, 100 a day), Brevo (300 a day), Postmark (100 a month), Amazon SES (pay per message).	$0 to start	M3

- Sending from your own domain needs three DNS records, which the provider gives you: **SPF** (who may send), **DKIM** (a signature) and **DMARC** (what receivers should do with mail that fails). A domain can have only one SPF record, so the provider's entry is merged with the one Email Routing created.
- Use the provider's HTTPS API rather than SMTP. Render's free instances block the SMTP ports.
- Email Routing cannot send. It is the front door for incoming mail only.

8. Stripe

The same three parts as PixelPerfect: **Checkout** (Stripe's hosted payment page), the **customer portal** (Stripe's hosted "manage my subscription" page) and **webhooks** (Stripe telling your server what happened). Using the hosted pages means card numbers never touch your server.

Step	What happens	Your code
1	The board's owner clicks Upgrade	The server creates a Checkout Session in subscription mode for that workspace and returns its URL
2	Stripe's page takes the card	None
3	Stripe calls your webhook: `checkout.session.completed`	Store the Stripe customer id and subscription id on the workspace
4	Stripe calls: `invoice.paid`	Mark the workspace as on the paid plan until the end of the period. **This event, not the browser's return, unlocks the plan.**
5	Each month: `invoice.paid` again, or `invoice.payment_failed`	Extend, or warn the owner
6	The owner opens "Manage billing"	The server creates a customer portal session and redirects there
7	Stripe calls: `customer.subscription.updated` or `.deleted`	When the status becomes canceled or unpaid, return the workspace to the free plan

Rules for the webhook endpoint (Stripe's own guidance)

- **Verify every call.** Check the `Stripe-Signature` header against the endpoint's signing secret, using the raw request body. In Java: `Webhook.constructEvent(payload, signatureHeader, secret)` from the official library, `com.stripe:stripe-java`. An unverified webhook lets anyone grant themselves the paid plan.
- **Expect duplicates.** Keep a table of processed event ids and ignore one you have already seen.
- **Expect them out of order.** Act on the state inside the event, not on the order of arrival.
- **Answer 200 quickly**, then do the work.
- **The route needs no login and no CSRF token**; the signature is its authentication. In `SecurityConfig` that is one more permitted path.
- **Secrets live in Render's environment**, never in the repository. Test and live keys differ, and so do their webhook secrets.

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Before you take a real payment

- Build and test in a Stripe **sandbox** with the test card `4242 4242 4242 4242`. The Stripe CLI forwards webhooks to your computer: `stripe listen --forward-to localhost:8080/stripe/webhook`.
- Stripe expects the public site to show: what is sold and its price, a way to reach support other than a form, a refund and cancellation policy, a privacy policy, and your business address.
- Consider a separate Stripe account for Brief! under your existing login, so its statement name and reports are not mixed with PixelPerfect's.
- A free plan needs no Stripe object at all. A workspace gets a Stripe customer only when its owner first clicks Upgrade.

Fees for a United States account, checked on the vendor's own pages on October 6, 2026: 2.9% + 30 cents per successful domestic card charge; Stripe Billing adds 0.7% of subscription volume on the pay-as-you-go plan; Stripe Tax, if you use it, 0.5% per transaction where you are registered. The customer portal is included.

9. Pricing Model

A price is a guess until someone pays it. What follows is a starting point to test in the validation gate, with the reasoning shown so you can change it.

What comparable tools charge

Product	Paid plan	List price	Unit	A team of 10 pays, per month
Slack	Pro	$8.75 monthly, $7.25 billed annually	per user	$87.50
Zulip Cloud	Standard	$8 monthly, $6.67 billed annually	per user	$80
Range	Pro	$8	per user	$80
Twist	Unlimited	$6	per user	$60
Microsoft Teams Essentials	-	$4, billed annually	per user	$40
Geekbot (stand-up bot)	Basic	$3 monthly, $2.50 billed annually	per participant	$30
Basecamp	Freelancer	$25	flat	$25

Public list prices checked on the vendor's own pages on October 6, 2026. These tools do far more than Brief!. They are shown to locate the ceiling, not to claim equivalence.

Proposed starting model: flat price per board

Plan	Price	Includes	Purpose
Free	$0	One board, up to 5 members, the last 90 days of posts	Lets a team start in a minute and feel the habit. The member limit, not a time limit, is what prompts the upgrade.
Team	**$12 a month per board**, or $120 a year	Up to 25 members, full history, mention alerts by email, export of posts	The plan most paying customers would be on
Larger	Later, on request	More members, single sign-on, audit log	Build only when someone asks

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Why flat, per board	Why about $12
Per-user pricing makes a manager count heads before inviting anyone. A flat price removes that hesitation, and inviting more colleagues makes the board more useful.	Brief! is an addition to a team's chat tool, not a replacement. It has to cost less than a decision. $12 is below every per-user tool above for a team of five or more.
Hosting cost barely changes with the number of members on a board; it follows the number of posts, and those are tiny.	A common rule in software pricing: two months free for paying annually ($120 instead of $144).
It is simple to explain and simple to build: one Stripe price, quantity one.	It can be raised for new customers later. Lowering a price is easy; raising it for existing customers is not.

What one paying board is worth

Per paying board, per month	Amount
Price	$12.00
Card fee: 2.9% + $0.30	- $0.65
Stripe Billing: 0.7%	- $0.08
Left before tax and hosting	**$11.27**
Fixed hosting at launch (Section 10)	$13 a month, whatever the number of boards
Paying boards needed to cover hosting	**2**

Read with care

These figures are arithmetic on list prices, not a forecast of income. They leave out sales tax (Section 11), refunds, disputes and your time. A free plan also has a cost: every free board uses the same server.

10. Monthly Cost at Each Stage

Item	M0 to M2 trial	Validation and launch	Growing
Domain (briefmessage.net)	Paid for the year; see your Cloudflare invoice	same	same
Cloudflare DNS, HTTPS certificate, email routing	$0	$0	$0
Render web service	$0 (sleeps when idle)	$7	$25
Render Postgres	$0 (deleted after 30 days)	$6	$19
Transactional email	-	$0 within the free allowance	about $15 to $20
Stripe	-	A share of each payment only	A share of each payment only
Fixed total per month	**$0**	**$13**	**about $60**

One-time: registering a DMCA agent with the United States Copyright Office costs $6 and is renewed every three years (Section 11).

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11. Legal and Compliance Checklist

A checklist of what a United States product with accounts and user-written content normally has at launch, with where to read more. **I am not a lawyer or a tax adviser.** Use this to prepare the conversation with one, not to replace it.

Item	What it is	Where to start
Terms of Service	The contract with users: acceptable use, what happens to content, how accounts end. State a minimum age of 13.	A lawyer, or a reputable template adapted to what Brief! really does
Privacy Policy	What you collect (username, email, posts, IP address in logs), why, who processes it (Render, Cloudflare, Stripe, the email provider), and how to delete it	Required by Stripe before live payments
Refund and cancellation policy	When a customer can cancel and whether anything is refunded	Stripe's website checklist: docs.stripe.com/get-started/checklist/website
Children (COPPA)	The law covers services directed at children under 13, or that knowingly collect their data. A work tool that states 13+ is the usual approach.	ftc.gov, COPPA frequently asked questions
Copyright complaints (DMCA)	Users can post text. Registering an agent ($6) and publishing a contact is part of the legal protection for hosts of user content.	copyright.gov/dmca-directory
New York sales tax	New York treats software accessed over the internet as taxable when sold to customers in New York. Selling subscriptions to New York customers likely means collecting it.	tax.ny.gov, bulletin TB-ST-128. Stripe Tax can calculate it. Confirm with an accountant.
Other states and countries	Rules differ and have thresholds. Most do not apply to a product with a handful of customers, but they start to matter as it grows.	An accountant; Stripe Tax's monitoring
Email (CAN-SPAM)	Marketing email needs a postal address and a working unsubscribe. Password resets and receipts are treated differently.	ftc.gov, CAN-SPAM compliance guide
European users (GDPR)	Applies if you offer the service to people in the EU, not merely because the site can be opened there.	Decide whether to market there before worrying
The business	OneTechly, LLC already exists and can own Brief!, as it owns PixelPerfect.	Your accountant, for how to keep the products' books apart
The name	"Brief" is a common word in software.	Search the USPTO trademark database before paying for a logo or advertising

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12. Scaling: What Breaks Next, and the Fix

Several items from the scaling table in OTSR v2 are done: signed tokens, paging, a rate limit, and as of 2.2 the mention index you asked about. What remains, in the order it will be needed:

Today	Becomes a problem when	Step	Milestone
H2 file database; schema changed by Hibernate at start-up	The first deployment	PostgreSQL; Flyway migrations; foreign keys	M1
Mention look-up scans all usernames for each new post	Tens of thousands of members	Count only names written with @ and look each up by index; make usernames unique regardless of capitals	M1 (usernames), later (@ only)
Mentions endpoint returns everything	A member mentioned thousands of times	Page it like the feed; the browser asks only for mentions newer than the last it saw	M1
Every browser asks every 15 seconds	Hundreds of people online at once	Server-Sent Events: the server pushes new posts down one open connection	After M4
Rate-limit counts and signed-out tokens in one server's memory	A second server instance, or the wish to keep them across restarts	Render Key Value (Redis-compatible), or shorter-lived tokens	When a second instance is needed
One instance	Memory or processor is the limit, or zero-downtime deploys matter	A larger instance first. Then two instances, which the step above makes possible.	When measured
Static files marked "do not cache"	Visitors far from the server, or many of them	Let the web app's files be cached; proxy through Cloudflare	M1 and after M2
One public board	The first team that wants privacy	A workspace id on every row and in every query	M4
Console logs only	The first problem you cannot reproduce	Structured logs, an uptime check, error alerts	M6

The order matters more than the list. Each step is taken when a measurement or a customer asks for it, not before. Brief! on one small instance with PostgreSQL will serve its first hundred teams.

13. This Week

1. **The Levrx take-home task.** It has a deadline and nothing here does.
2. **Run Brief! 2.2.0's tests** and send the result: `Tests run: 149` is the line to look for.
3. **M0, 30 minutes:** auto-renew, DNSSEC, two-factor authentication on the Cloudflare account, and the two forwarding addresses.
4. **Decide two things** and tell me: (a) is direction B, private boards for small teams, the product; (b) should 2.3 be the deployable build described in M1. With a yes to (b), the next release brings PostgreSQL, Flyway, the Dockerfile and a `render.yaml`, tested as far as can be done before your machine runs it.

> **Bottom line**
>
> Nothing in this plan needs money before the validation gate, and the gate needs only $13 a month. The expensive part is your time. That is the reason the gate is where it is.

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